rapid reaction to address the surging protests. “We want … through a number of changes, including the travel law, to [create] the chance, the sovereign decision of the citizens to travel wherever they want.” He added with caution, “We are naturally concerned that the possibilities of this travel regulation—it is still not in effect, it’s only a draft.” Schabowski inadvertently revealed the GDR’s plans to begin lifting travel restrictions and issuing more visas for permanent exit before procedures were secured. Though he noted the policy was being refined ahead of its implementation, Schabowski failed to notice instructions in his own papers that the announcement of any such plans was to be withheld until the following day, to allow the GDR to fully prepare and manage the new policy. However, when he was asked after his extended remarks at the press conference when this would all take effect, he quickly consulted his papers in front of him and responded, “right away.”[5]

Mary Elise Sarotte documents the East German party’s intentions in drafted language inadvertently shared by Schabowski. Their goal was to “[promote] freedom of travel” with “caveats—it was only temporary, still required multiple forms of permission” with the goal “to prevent the depopulation of East Germany.”[6] But Schabowski’s admission carried profound consequences. News of such a drastic and immediate amendment to concrete state policy did not break at once, but within several hours the consequences of this unplanned divulgence began to unfold at the city’s internal border areas.[7] For the next several hours, as the East German authorities and unprepared border guards scrambled, crowds began to gather at several crossing points throughout the city. At approximately 11:30 P.M., East Berliners pushed down a security fence at the Bornholmer Strasse checkpoint. Then a flood began that the authorities did not stop.

The news traveled overseas to U.S. audiences, who continued to demonstrate great interest in the fate of divided Berlin. For example, that day newscaster Peter Jennings issued a special report for ABC News from his desk in New York City. In the first hours after the news broke, Jennings shared initial details, observing on-air, “What will happen now is hard to tell.”[8] The following evening, on November 10, Tom Brokaw of NBC News, who was present at the Schabowski press conference, broadcast the evening news live from the west side of the Brandenburg Gate. Brokaw opened the program with a nod to the atmosphere: “The sound that you hear, and what you’re seeing tonight, not hammers and sickles, but hammers and chisels, as